



THE MODERN



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EGGS ON EGGS ON EGGS

Kaluga Caviar | Poached Egg Yolk | Egg Sauce | Fried Brioche
Fresh Dill | Dill Oil

SEMOLINA PAIN AU LAIT

HIRAMASA

Cured Hiramasa | Green Tomatoes | Basil
Tapioca | Cucumber | Granny Smith

SCALLOP

Seared Scallop | Celtuce Ribbon | Spinach | Fresh Yuzu | Parsley Powder
Brown Butter Grenobloise

DUCK

21-Day Dry-Aged Duck | Green Asparagus | Cherry
Basil Oil | Cherry Black Truffle Bordelaise

BEEF

Beef | Maitake | Spring Onion
Dried Cherry | Watercress | Sauce Bordelaise

MATCHA VACHERIN

Houjicha Chiffon Cake | Meringue Cylinder | Matcha Moussed
Puffed Jasmine Rice | Buckwheat Seeds | Soft Chantilly
Jasmine Pearl Ice Cream | Matcha Powder

CHOCOLATE

Manjari Chocolate | Almond Praline Mousse | Hazelnut Feuilletine Crust
Rum Vanilla Ice Cream | Candied Macona Almond | Cocoa Nib |
White Chocolate Parfait | Maldon Salt





EGGS ON EGGS ON EGGS

The prix-fixe lunch tasting menu at The Modern unfolds on the most esteemed dish, the Eggs on Eggs on Eggs. Nestling inside the ceramic egg-shaped bowl, the dish comprises three variations of eggs — a soft-boiled egg yolk and a scoop of sturgeon caviar on top with a rich egg sauce lying at the bottom. Carrying rich oceanic umami, the caviar is engulfed in a swamp of egg yolk and egg sauce that evoke lavish creaminess in similar yet altered ways. The extravagantly refreshing and aromatic dill oil and fresh dill are introduced to counter the unctuousness and heaviness of the melange, while a strip of extra-airy fried French brioche is paired to balance the whole texture with crispiness and airiness. The only regret is that the caviar fails to shine when immersed in the rich sauce, and the medley of the three “eggs” eventually becomes a complementary component for the brioche.

SEMOLINA PAIN AU LAIT

A lot has changed in the past four years at The Modern, yet a lot remains the same. The bread course featuring mini brioche paired with rosemary-scented butter back in 2018 was one of the most mind-blowing moments of that gourmet journey, and I can still recall the fascinating herbal aroma of the butter. Today, we witness another great bread service at The Modern. Though paired with ordinary butter, the Semolina pain au lait made with Semolina flour, a type of coarse and purified wheat middlings of durum wheat, shocked our palate again with its extremely soft and airy texture. Albeit its inferior in comparison to the creaminess and delicacy of the brioche in the previous course, it is subtly molded in a rural and pristine style.





SCALLOP

Following the raw hiramasa with pungent acidity is the second appetizer on the contrary style, a warm and rich scallop dish of seared scallop paired with celtuce ribbons and spinach, finished with a brown butter grenobloise sauce.

The scallop is seared to perfection, with a gorgeous thin outer layer of caramelization and an evenly-cooked medium-rare core. The scallop is crowned with some greens, namely celtuce ribbons and spinach, both of which invoke only neutral flavors that fail to create dimensions of flavors in this dish. A relatively rich brown butter grenobloise sauce is added to the dish, ornamented with parsley powder and small chunks of yuzu. The grenobloise as a play on the traditional sauce Meunière is comprised of butter, lemon, parsley, and capers. The sauce not only provides creaminess to the scallop but also works well with the mild nuttiness of the celtuce.

HIRAMASA

The official entrance of the prix fixe menu is marked by the two appetizers, one of which is the raw cured hiramasa paired with green tomatoes, basil, cucumber, and granny smith. The cured hiramasa exhibits a lightly firmer texture and more concentrated umami, which are further enhanced when it encounters the shades of acidity in green tomatoes and granny smith. Both the tomatoes and apples are green varieties, which guarantee exuberant acidity to denature the proteins while avoiding overwhelming the flesh with unnecessary sweetness. The addition of basil and cucumber provides essential refreshing herbal scents that sing in perfect harmony with the oceanic umami of the hiramasa. For other minor perspectives, tapioca is introduced to enhance the variety of texture, while some edible flowers are added to evoke faint floral aromas.





DRY AGED DUCK

The Modern's main courses never let me down, and so does today's duck and beef.

The first main course we picked from the menu is a duck breast dish comprising two pieces of duck breast aged for twenty-one days, green asparagus, and some fresh cherry finished with a cherry black truffle bordelaise and basil oil. The duck is so well cooked to medium rare that the knife cuts through the tender flesh and the crispy skin unbelievably smoothly, almost as easy as cutting through a piece of tofu. With regard to its flavor, the breast exhibits more concentrated umami than regular duck, thanks to the dry aging process. The pairing of duck with cherry never goes wrong, and the freshness of the cherry further lightens the whole flavor profile together with the green asparagus. The cherry black truffle bordelaise carries a rich savor yet with a light texture so that it significantly enriches the duck breast yet avoids overwhelming the pristine condition of the duck.

BEEF TENDERLOIN

Along with the duck comes the beef tenderloin, similarly constructed of some vegetables and dried cherries, finished with a Bordelaise sauce. The beef tenderloin is as tender as the duck. Though it won't melt in your mouth like a fine cut of Miyazaki wagyu beef, it does carry a more accentuated texture as well as a rich buttery aroma and flavor that stir my emotions. The grilled young spring onion, fresh watercress, and sautéed maitake counterpoint the beef tenderloin, enlivening the whole with faint yet essential nuances of earthy aroma, green notes, and slight sweetness. An additional splendid touch of the dried cherry and bordelaise sauce embraces the whole with a condensed richness. The chef plays a safe game on both dishes. The pairing of red meat with cherry and bordelaise sauce is such a classic move that, on the one hand, one can barely make a mistake on it, on the other hand, such a design is hard to please those who aim for innovation. Albeit the non-surprising design, the main dishes are prepared to finesse in every detail.





MATCHA VACHERIN

One of the new desserts composed by executive pastry chef Kazuo Fujimura for the upcoming hot season is a refreshing matcha vacherin dessert. A typical vacherin is a dessert consisting of meringue and a filling. In this case, it comprises a base of houjicha chiffon cake within a meringue cylinder, a matcha mousse filling counterpointed by puffed jasmine rice, and buckwheat seeds, a soft matcha-powdered chantilly cloud on the top, as well as a quenelle of jasmine pearl ice cream. Regardless of the complex design of the component, it is unlikely a successful dessert as one can hardly get layers of flavors and textures out of this creation. The textures are rustic, the flavors are unclearly piled up, and the plating design is poor. The only part that shocks my tongue was the fabulous jasmine ice cream which carries a sensual floral aroma. One can easily expect such a dessert at a tavern or a cafe.

CHOCOLATE

The other new dessert is a chocolate dessert showcasing chef Fujimura's new interpretation of the New Yorkers' favorite black-and-white cookies. For his version, the dessert consists of a black column of Manjari chocolate, almond praline mousse, and hazelnut feuilletine crust, a white medallion of white chocolate parfait finished with Maldon salt nestling on top of rum vanilla ice cream and candied macon almond and cocoa nibs. The ordinary amalgamation of chocolate, hazelnut, and vanilla further repels us with the unrefined texture and overwhelming sweetness. The overall dessert selections let us down, and I have to admit that I miss the old days when former executive pastry chef Jiho Kim was in charge of the dessert station.





Aside from the high-standard cuisine, the vibe during lunchtime is what seduces me all the time to dine at The Modern. Besides within the MoMA, the restaurant inherits the elegant contemporary aesthetics of the museum.

The gigantic floor-to-ceiling windows allow sunbeams to fully shine through, the extra white linens provide a large blank canvas, the vogue dinnerwares by Herring Berlin and other noble brands and stylish cutleries correspond with the modern atmosphere, the office chairs loosen the seriousness of fine dining, and the keep-changing seasonal flowers touch the whole scene with a brief decorative vividness.

In celebration of my twenty-third birthday, I bring two bottles of Burgundy reds from my birth year, which happens to be one of the greatest years of this region. The 1999 Clos de Tart and 1999 Clos de la Roche from Armand Rousseau are uncorked when the first caviar course is served, and are tasted side by side when we enjoy the main course. Surprisingly, the Clos de Tart is still tight and bewilders my palate with its pungent tannin. On the nose and the palate, it shows mainly red floral and fruity notes, but with refreshing woodiness and black tea-like and citrusy tones. The Clos de la Roche, on the other hand, exhibits a much soft and creamier texture with a gracefully silky tannin yet a grand body. The aroma and palate show darker fruity and floral scents, and a rich sophisticated aroma reminiscent of chocolate.

